

HelixHack 2026

Silicon Circle's First Teen Innovation Hackathon

Chennai, India | October 2026

1. What Is HelixHack?

HelixHack is Silicon Circle's inaugural teen innovation hackathon, held in Chennai in October 2026. It is a city-wide, team-based event that challenges students from Grade 8 to Grade 12 to design and build solutions to real-world problems across four themes, using science, technology, engineering, and mathematics as their foundation.

Teams participate in one of two categories: Pitch-Only (ideation and research-based) or Prototype (working model, app, hardware, or software). The event spans online qualifying rounds followed by an offline finale demo day held during the Navratri school holidays on Saturday, October 18, 2026.

Why Silicon Circle Is Organising This

Most hackathons available to teens in Chennai are too senior in scope, too niche, or not locally accessible. HelixHack fills that gap by creating a structured, mentored, and genuinely rigorous competition designed specifically for school-age innovators.

Silicon Circle is a teen-led community. This hackathon reflects the belief that students do not need to wait until they graduate before making meaningful contributions to real problems. We are creating the platform we wish had existed when we started.

Event Format at a Glance

Item	Details
Event Name	HelixHack 2026 (name to be finalised)
Organiser	Silicon Circle
Location	Chennai, Tamil Nadu, India
Participation Region	Chennai city — open to all Chennai-based teens
Grade Range	Grade 8 to Grade 12
Team Size	2 to 5 members per team; members may be from different schools
Format	Online qualifying rounds + Offline finale demo day
Categories	Pitch-Only (ideation) Prototype (working implementation)
Registration Opens	Tuesday, September 15, 2026
Registration Closes	Thursday, September 25, 2026
Finale Date	Saturday, October 18, 2026 (Navratri school holiday window)
Starting Budget	Domain and server hosting only; all other costs funded via fees and collaborator

2. Themes

All teams must build their project within one of the four themes below. Themes are intentionally broad to allow creative interpretation, while focused enough to give teams a clear problem space to work within.

Theme 1: AI & Emerging Technology

Projects that use, explore, or critically examine artificial intelligence, machine learning, automation, computer vision, robotics, or other cutting-edge technologies to solve a real-world problem.

- **Example problems:** AI tools that identify struggling students early; automated waste sorting systems; local-language AI assistants for non-English speakers in Chennai.

Theme 2: Sustainability & Climate

Projects focused on environmental preservation, renewable energy, climate resilience, food security, water conservation, or building a more sustainable future for urban communities.

- **Example problems:** Rooftop rainwater harvesting systems for Chennai apartments; apps that track a school's carbon footprint; biodegradable alternatives to single-use plastics.

Theme 3: Mental Health, Student Wellbeing & EdTech

Projects that address mental health challenges faced by students, or that use technology to improve how young people learn, study, and grow. This theme bridges emotional wellbeing with educational innovation.

- **Example problems:** A peer-support platform for school students; a smart study scheduler that accounts for stress and burnout; gamified revision tools built for board exam pressure.

Theme 4: Accessibility & Inclusion

Projects that remove barriers for people with disabilities, language differences, economic disadvantages, or other challenges that limit their full participation in society, education, or technology.

- **Example problems:** Sign-language translation tools; low-cost assistive devices for visually impaired students; simplified apps for first-generation smartphone users.

3. Participation

Who Can Participate

- Students currently enrolled in Grade 8 through Grade 12 at any Chennai school.
- Independent teens not affiliated with a school are also eligible to apply.
- Teams may include members from different schools.
- All participants must be in Chennai for the offline finale round.

Team Structure

Parameter	Rule
Minimum team size	2 members
Maximum team size	5 members
Cross-school teams	Allowed and encouraged
Independent participants	Allowed; must form or join a team to compete
Registration	One Google Form submission per team; one Team ID issued per team

Categories

There are two categories in HelixHack. They are fundamentally different in format, presentation style, and what teams are expected to produce. Teams select their category at registration and compete only against other teams in the same category.

Pitch-Only

Teams develop a well-researched, evidence-backed idea for solving a real problem. No working prototype is required. The emphasis is on depth of thinking, scientific rationale, feasibility, and the ability to communicate a compelling case to an audience.

- **Finale format:** Stage presentation. Teams present to the full audience and judging panel from the stage in timed, scheduled slots. This is a live, structured pitch — no stall, no walkabout.
- **Time per team:** 5-minute presentation + 3-minute Q&A from judges, delivered on stage.
- **What to bring:** A slide deck (displayed on the main screen), printed supporting materials or research references, and a confident, prepared speaker or co-speakers from the team.
- **What is judged:** Quality of the problem framing, depth of research, STEM basis, feasibility of the proposed solution, and clarity of presentation.
- **Vibe coding note:** If any AI tools were used to assist in research, writing, or slide generation, team members must be able to explain and own all content presented.

Prototype

Teams build a working implementation of their solution. This can be software, a hardware device, a physical model, a web or mobile app, or any functional artefact that demonstrates the solution in action.

- **Finale format:** Stall-based expo. Teams are assigned a dedicated stall in the exhibition hall. Judges and guests walk freely through the hall and visit each team at their stall throughout the judging window.
- **Time per team:** Approximately 8–10 minutes per judge visit: 5-minute walkthrough of the prototype + 3–5 minutes of Q&A and hands-on demonstration.
- **What to bring:** The working prototype or live demo, a project poster, any charts or data visualisations, and supporting printed materials. Teams are responsible for setting up and decorating their own stall.
- **What is judged:** All Pitch-Only criteria plus the quality and sophistication of the actual implementation. The prototype must be functional and demonstrable on the day.
- **Vibe coding note:** AI-assisted development is permitted. However, judges will ask teams to walk through sections of their code or hardware logic directly. Teams unable to explain their implementation will face score deductions.

Both categories use the same core scoring rubric and compete within the same four themes. The Execution & Quality criterion is weighted more heavily for Prototype teams. Stage and stall judging run simultaneously at the finale, with judges divided between both formats.

Vibe Coding and AI Tool Policy

The use of AI-assisted coding and development tools is permitted in HelixHack. This includes tools such as GitHub Copilot, Cursor, ChatGPT, Claude, v0, Replit AI, and any similar AI pair-programming or code-generation assistant.

One rule applies without exception: every team member must be able to fully explain their code, logic, design decisions, and implementation to judges at any point during the event.

Core principle: AI is a tool, not a team member. Teams are evaluated on their understanding and application of technology, not on their ability to prompt a model.

- **Permitted:** Using AI tools to generate, assist, debug, or refactor code; scaffold boilerplate; generate design assets; or summarise background research.
- **Permitted:** Using AI-generated code or components, provided the team fully understands what the code does and why.
- **Not permitted:** Using AI to generate the core problem identification or innovation idea. The insight, framing, and direction of the solution must originate from the team.
- **Not permitted:** Submitting AI-generated work that team members cannot explain. This is treated as academic dishonesty and results in disqualification.
- **Judge expectation:** At the finale, judges will ask teams to walk through sections of their code or implementation and explain what it does and why that approach was chosen. Inability to answer clearly will result in score deductions under the STEM Integration and Presentation criteria.

5. School Ambassador Programme

School Ambassadors are student representatives from Chennai schools who drive registrations and awareness within their institutions. Each ambassador is the official Silicon Circle point of contact at their school.

Ambassador Responsibilities

- Distribute registration information and links within their school.
- Organise a short intro session or announcement at their school using Silicon Circle materials.
- Act as first point of contact for queries from students at their school.
- Encourage their school's teams to stay active throughout all rounds of the hackathon.

What Ambassadors Receive

- **Title:** "Silicon Circle Ambassador" — an officially recognised and credited role.
- **Certificate:** An official Silicon Circle Ambassador certificate, usable for college applications and extracurricular portfolios.
- **Priority Registration:** The ambassador's own team receives priority registration status.
- **Innov8 Access:** Ambassadors and the students they recruit receive exclusive access to Silicon Circle's monthly Innov8 event: a recurring challenge where participants solve 8 problems across STEM and innovation. HelixHack is the entry point into a sustained community, not a one-off event.
- **School Cup Credit:** The ambassador's school contributes toward the School Cup — recognition for the school whose teams collectively perform best across all rounds.

6. Registration

Key Registration Dates

Date	Milestone
Mon, Sep 15	REGISTRATIONS OPEN. Ambassador activation. Marketing blast.
Fri, Sep 26 (Evening)	Mandatory GMeet Info Session for all registered participants.
Wed-Thu, Sep 24-25	Final registration push. Ambassador follow-ups at schools.
Thu, Sep 25 (EOD)	REGISTRATIONS CLOSE. Team count confirmed. Path A or Path B activated.
Fri, Sep 26 (morning)	Post-registration agenda, Team ID, and Round 1 schedule sent to all teams.

GMeet Info Session — September 26, 2026

A compulsory GMeet session held the day after registrations close. At least one team member per team must attend. Agenda:

- Event overview and full rules walkthrough
- Theme and category explanation with example projects
- Discord server onboarding and daily log requirement explanation
- Round 1 format and what judges expect
- Q&A with Arnav and Maanas

7. Round Structure

The round structure depends on total registered teams. Silicon Circle will assess the count immediately after registrations close on September 25 and announce the path that same evening.

(2 Rounds)
Round 1: Online GMeet pitch to judges
Teams choose theme and category at Round 1
Round 2: Offline Finale — Stall Demo Day
Build Period: ~18 days before finale

Round 1: Online GMeet Pitch (Sep 26-28)

Item	Details
Format	Live GMeet presentation to judges in scheduled slots
Duration	5-minute pitch + 3-minute Q&A per team
Content	Problem being solved, proposed solution, chosen theme and category, STEM basis for the approach
Judged by	Collaborator judges using the Silicon Circle scoring rubric
Results	Announced September 29. Written, specific feedback sent to every team within 48 hours.
Advancement	Top teams advance to the Build Period and Finale. Eliminated teams receive full written feedback.

Path A, Round 2: Offline Finale Demo Day (October 18, 2026)

See Section 9 for the full Finale schedule and stall format.

Build Period (Both Paths)

Once finalists are confirmed, the Build Period begins. Teams have approximately 2 weeks to develop, build, and refine their solution before the finale.

- Path A Build Period: September 29 to October 17 (approximately 18 days)
- Path B Build Period: October 3 to October 17 (14 days)
- Daily Discord progress uploads are mandatory throughout the Build Period. See Section 11.
- Finale registration fee payment opens at the start of the Build Period.

8. Evaluation Criteria

8.1 Scoring Rubric — 100 Points

All rounds use the same core rubric, adapted for each round format. Judges apply the rubric independently; Silicon Circle aggregates scores.

All rounds use the same core rubric. At the finale, the two categories are judged by separate panels: a stage panel for Pitch-Only and a stall panel for Prototype. Results are tallied separately — Pitch-Only and Prototype have distinct 1st, 2nd, and 3rd place placements.

Criterion	Points	Pitch-Only — What Judges Look For	Prototype — What Judges Look For
Innovation & Originality	25 pts	Is the idea novel? Does it address a real problem in a creative or non-obvious way?	Same. Does the chosen implementation approach reflect creative problem-solving?
STEM Integration	20 pts	Is there a clear scientific, engineering, or mathematical basis presented? Are data and calculations used to validate the solution?	Is the technical implementation grounded in sound engineering or computer science? Can the team explain the science behind their build?
Feasibility & Practicality	25 pts	Could this idea realistically be built or implemented? Are constraints, costs, and resources acknowledged?	Does the prototype demonstrate a viable, scalable approach? Are the engineering trade-offs understood?
Impact & Theme Relevance	15 pts	How significant is the problem? Does the proposed solution meaningfully align with the chosen theme?	Same. Does the working prototype address a meaningful problem within the chosen theme?
Execution & Quality	10 pts	Depth and clarity of the idea. Research quality. Strength of the slide deck and arguments.	Quality of the working prototype.

			Reliability of the demo. Technical sophistication and completeness of implementation. Weighted more heavily than for Pitch-Only.
Presentation & Communication	10 pts	Stage presence, clarity of delivery, and ability to handle judge Q&A confidently and accurately.	Ability to walk judges through the prototype fluently, explain technical decisions, and answer pointed implementation questions.
Daily Discord Consistency	+5 bonus	Consistency and quality of daily progress logs during the Build Period. Scored by Silicon Circle.	Same.

8.2 Special Awards

In addition to main rubric placements, the following special awards are given at the finale:

- **People's Choice Award:** Voted on by the public via social media during the Build Period. Silicon Circle posts team progress highlights on Instagram and LinkedIn. The team with the most engagement wins. Completely separate from judge placements.
- **Best Stall Award:** Judge discretion at the finale. Awarded to the team with the most creative, well-organised, and visually effective stall presentation.
- **Best STEM Implementation:** Awarded to the team whose project most rigorously applies science, engineering, or mathematics — regardless of final placement. Recognises technical depth.
- **School Cup:** Awarded to the school whose teams collectively score highest across all rounds. Tracked by Silicon Circle throughout the event and announced at the finale. Encourages school-level participation and gives ambassadors a tangible goal.
- **Silicon Circle Fellows:** A formal recognition given to the most promising teams eliminated in earlier rounds. Not a consolation prize — a genuine title. Fellows are invited into the Silicon Circle community and highlighted in post-event communications. No good idea goes unacknowledged.
- **Daily Discord Star:** Awarded to the finalist team with the most consistent, detailed, and high-quality daily build logs. Judged by Silicon Circle organisers.

8.3 Feedback Policy

Silicon Circle is committed to giving every team — including eliminated teams — specific, written, individual feedback after every round. Every participant deserves to know why they advanced or why they did not, and what they can concretely improve.

- Feedback is individual to each team — not generic templated responses.
- Feedback is delivered by email and on the dashboard within 48 hours of results announcement.
- Judge scores are aggregated and summarised; individual judge names are not disclosed to teams.

9. Finale — Demo Day

9.1 Overview

Item	Details
Date	Saturday, October 18, 2026
Context	Navratri school holiday window (October 11-19, 2026) — no school conflict for any participant
Location	Exhibition hall with a stage, Chennai (venue to be booked; see Section 15)
Format	Dual-format: Pitch-Only teams present on stage; Prototype teams present at stalls. Both run simultaneously.
Entry	Paid registration for finalists (covers venue + lunch). Guests and parents welcome.

9.2 Stage Format — Pitch-Only Category

Pitch-Only finalist teams present from the main stage in front of the full audience. Presentations are scheduled in fixed time slots throughout the judging window. The entire audience — including guests, parents, other teams, and the judging panel — watches each stage pitch live.

- Each team's slot is 5 minutes of presentation + 3 minutes of judge Q&A from the judging panel seated at the front.
- Slides are displayed on the main screen. Teams must submit their slide deck on the website by midnight on October 17.
- Teams present in a pre-assigned order. The schedule is published to all Pitch-Only finalists at least 48 hours before the finale.
- Audience may not interrupt or ask questions. Only judges ask questions during the Q&A portion.
- All STEM rationale, data, and research must be evident in the slide deck and defensible in Q&A.

9.3 Stall Format — Prototype Category

Prototype finalist teams are each assigned a dedicated stall in the exhibition hall. Judges and guests walk freely through the hall, visiting each team at their stall throughout the judging window. This mirrors a real-world science fair or startup expo, and gives students the experience of defending their implementation to multiple evaluators in a professional environment.

- Each team receives approximately 8-10 minutes per judge visit: 5-minute prototype walkthrough + 3-5 minute Q&A and hands-on demonstration.
- Teams are responsible for decorating and setting up their stall. Stall setup time is 9:00–9:30 AM. Stall aesthetics contribute to the Best Stall Award.
- Teams must bring the working prototype, a printed project poster, supporting data or diagrams, and any devices or hardware needed to demonstrate the solution live.

- All STEM components must be visually displayed or live-demonstrable at the stall. Judges will ask teams to operate or demonstrate their prototype directly.
- Judges are divided across both stage and stall judging. A dedicated sub-panel handles stall walkarounds while another handles the stage Q&A.

9.4 Full Finale Schedule — Saturday, October 18, 2026

Time	Activity
9:00 AM	Venue opens. Volunteers at entry: pass and ID distribution. Prototype teams proceed to their assigned stalls. Pitch-Only teams collect their stage slot schedule.
9:00 - 9:30 AM	Prototype teams set up stalls: posters, prototypes, displays. Pitch-Only teams do a final slide check with the Silicon Circle AV volunteer on stage.
9:30 - 10:00 AM	Icebreaker Bingo session. All teams mingle — Pitch-Only and Prototype together. See Section 13.
10:00 AM	JUDGING BEGINS. Both formats run simultaneously. Stage judging: Pitch-Only teams present in scheduled slots to the stage judge panel. Stall judging: Stall judge panel walks the exhibition floor visiting Prototype teams. Audience is free to watch stage presentations or visit stalls.
10:00 AM - 12:30 PM	Judging window. Pitch-Only stage slots run back-to-back with 1-minute transitions. Prototype stall judges rotate across all stalls. Guests and parents may attend stage presentations and visit stalls freely throughout.
12:30 PM	Judging concludes for both formats. All teams stand down. Lunch break. People's Choice Vote closes on social media.
1:30 PM	Speaker session on stage: representative from the collaborator addresses all participants. All teams attend.
2:00 PM	Judge score consolidation and deliberation off-stage, handled by Silicon Circle. Stage and stall panels submit final scores separately.
3:00 PM	Results announced on stage. Special awards first (People's Choice, Best Stall, Best STEM, School Cup, Silicon Circle Fellows, Discord Star), then category placements: Pitch-Only 3rd, 2nd, 1st; then Prototype 3rd, 2nd, 1st.
3:30 PM	Prize and certificate distribution on stage. Collaborator representative presents to category winners.
4:00 PM	Group photos, open networking, and informal venue time.
4:30 PM	Venue closes. Event ends.

10. Prizes

Prize amounts are to be finalised in discussion with the collaborator. The prize structure and award categories below are confirmed. Cash values are TBD.

Award	Prize
PITCH-ONLY CATEGORY	
Pitch-Only — 1st Place	Cash prize (TBD) + Trophy + Certificate + Incubation access with collaborator + Joint recognition letter
Pitch-Only — 2nd Place	Cash prize (TBD) + Trophy + Certificate + Joint recognition letter
Pitch-Only — 3rd Place	Cash prize (TBD) + Trophy + Certificate
PROTOTYPE CATEGORY	
Prototype — 1st Place	Cash prize (TBD) + Trophy + Certificate + Incubation access with collaborator + Joint recognition letter
Prototype — 2nd Place	Cash prize (TBD) + Trophy + Certificate + Joint recognition letter
Prototype — 3rd Place	Cash prize (TBD) + Trophy + Certificate
SPECIAL AWARDS	
People's Choice Award	Certificate + Spot prize (TBD) — open to both categories
Best STEM Implementation	Certificate + Spot prize (TBD) — open to both categories
Best Stall Award	Certificate — Prototype category only
Silicon Circle Fellows	Recognition certificate + Official Silicon Circle community membership
Daily Discord Star	Certificate — open to both categories
All Participants	Certificate of Participation — every registered team receives one regardless of advancement

*Certificates are issued for all rounds, including teams eliminated in Round 1 and Round 2.
Participation is always recognised.*

11. Discord Daily Progress Protocol

During the Build Period, all finalist teams are required to post daily progress updates in the Silicon Circle Discord server's dedicated finalist channel. This requirement exists for three reasons: accountability, community energy, and fuelling the People's Choice vote.

What Each Update Must Include

- One or more photos showing physical or digital progress made that day.
- A written typeout of at least 3-5 sentences covering: what was done today, what worked, what didn't work, and what is next.

Rules

- **Frequency:** One update per day, every day of the Build Period. Missed days reduce the Daily Discord bonus score (up to +5 points at finale).
- **Authenticity:** Updates must reflect genuine daily progress. Copying previous updates or submitting placeholder posts is flagged and penalised.
- **Content scope:** Share the process, not the punchline. Teams are not required to reveal their core innovation idea publicly, only the build journey.
- **Channel:** Updates posted to the private finalist channel. Silicon Circle selects highlights to reshare publicly on Instagram and LinkedIn for the People's Choice vote.

People's Choice Integration

Silicon Circle will curate and repost team build highlights on Instagram and LinkedIn throughout the Build Period. The public engages with these posts. The team accumulating the most votes across the campaign wins the People's Choice Award at the finale.

12. STEM Integration

HelixHack is not just a technology competition. It is a STEM event. Every project, regardless of theme or category, must demonstrate grounding in science, technology, engineering, or mathematics. Here is how STEM is embedded throughout HelixHack.

In Judging

"STEM Integration" is a dedicated criterion worth 20 points on the rubric in every round. Judges specifically assess whether teams have used data, calculations, engineering principles, or scientific reasoning to design and validate their solutions.

In Project Requirements

- Pitch-Only teams must include data, statistics, or scientific rationale to support their proposed solution.
- Prototype teams must demonstrate a functional technical implementation and be able to explain the engineering decisions made.
- All teams should be prepared to answer: "What is the science, engineering, or mathematics behind why your solution works?"

Encouraged Technical Approaches

- Using real-world data or publicly available datasets to validate a problem or solution.
- Building hardware prototypes using tools like Arduino, Raspberry Pi, sensors, or similar.
- Applying mathematical modelling, simulation, or statistical analysis.
- Conducting a structured mini-experiment to test feasibility.
- Using code (Python, JavaScript, or any language) to automate, analyse, visualise, or implement.
- Creating scientifically grounded posters, charts, or diagrams for the stall presentation.

STEM Award

The "Best STEM Implementation" award is given specifically to the team whose project most rigorously and creatively applies STEM principles, whether through mathematics, physical engineering, scientific experimentation, or code. This award is separate from the main placement rubric and can go to any team regardless of final position.

13. What Makes HelixHack Different

HelixHack is designed to be more than a competition. The elements below distinguish it from a generic hackathon and give it genuine character.

- **People's Choice Award:** Public social media voting during the Build Period gives every team an audience, not just judges. Teams have a reason to share their work and build community support, making HelixHack a visible public event, not a closed competition.
- **School Cup:** Schools compete through their teams' collective performance. This motivates ambassadors, excites school administrations, and creates school-level investment in the event beyond individual teams.
- **Silicon Circle Fellows:** Rather than simply eliminating teams after Round 1 or 2, HelixHack formally recognises the most promising non-finalists with the 'Silicon Circle Fellows' title and community membership. No exceptional idea is dismissed without acknowledgment.
- **Icebreaker Bingo at the Finale:** Before judging begins, all teams play an Icebreaker Bingo game. Each square on the bingo card is filled by meeting a team with a specific trait (for example: has a hardware prototype; team from three different schools; uses machine learning; solving a local Chennai problem). Teams mix, talk, and connect before the high-pressure judging session starts. This turns the waiting period into genuine community.
- **Mandatory Individual Feedback for All:** Every team, including those eliminated in Round 1, receives specific and individual written feedback. This is rare in student competitions and is a non-negotiable Silicon Circle value. Participants leave with actionable insight regardless of outcome.
- **Daily Build Logs:** The Discord log requirement makes the hackathon a visible, documented journey rather than a black box. It teaches teams to communicate progress under pressure, a critical professional and academic skill.
- **Website Easter Egg:** A hidden puzzle embedded in the HelixHack website, discoverable by curious visitors who explore the site thoroughly. The first team to find and solve it wins a small prize or special recognition. Rewards genuine engagement with our digital presence.
- **Monthly Innov8 Community:** Every HelixHack participant is invited to join Silicon Circle's monthly Innov8 challenge: a recurring event where participants solve 8 problems across STEM and innovation domains. HelixHack is the starting point for an ongoing community, not a standalone event.

14. Full Weekly Timeline

This timeline covers every phase from internal preparation through to the finale and post-event. Dates are structured around the Chennai school exam schedule (September) and the Navratri holiday window (October 11-19, 2026).

Parallel Track: Silicon Circle Nonprofit Registration

Registering Silicon Circle as a formal nonprofit organisation is an administrative priority running alongside the main hackathon prep. Nonprofit status is required to open a dedicated organisation bank account, sign legally binding collaborator agreements, receive sponsorship funds, and establish institutional credibility with schools and industry partners.

Milestone	Action and Notes
Week 1 (Jul 1-7)	Research nonprofit structures available in Tamil Nadu: Society (Societies Registration Act 1860), Public Trust, or Section 8 Company (Companies Act 2013). Discuss choice with mentor. Section 8 Company is recommended for maximum institutional credibility with industry collaborators. Confirm with a CA or legal advisor.
Week 2 (Jul 8-14)	Prepare required documentation: Memorandum of Association and bye-laws or Articles of Association, list of founding members, registered office address in Chennai, identity and address proofs. Draft Silicon Circle mission statement and stated objectives for the registration filing.
Week 3 (Jul 15-21)	File registration application with the relevant authority. For Society: file with the Registrar of Societies, Tamil Nadu. For Section 8 Company: file on the MCA21 portal with the Ministry of Corporate Affairs. Engage a CA or legal advisor for filing if needed.
Weeks 4-8	Follow up on registration status. Processing time is typically 30 to 90 days depending on structure chosen. In the interim, use a personal account for minimal early expenses. Update collaborator pitch deck to reflect pending nonprofit registration status.
Upon Registration	Open a dedicated Silicon Circle organisation bank account immediately. Update website and all event materials with the official registered name and registration number. Use this account for all collaborator agreements, sponsorship receipts, and finale financial transactions.

Phase 1: Foundation (Weeks 1-4 | July 1 - July 28, 2026)

Week	Goals and Key Activities
Week 1 Jul 1-7	Finalise event name, themes, and categories. Define judging criteria and draft scoring rubric. Begin website and hackathon subdomain development. Set up internal Arnav and Maanas task board and ownership split. Begin drafting collaborator pitch deck.
Week 2 Jul 8-14	Complete website version 1. Create brand identity: logo, colour palette, typography. Set up Discord server structure with channels, roles, and welcome flow. Draft school ambassador programme document with all perks and responsibilities.

Week 3Jul 15-21	Complete collaborator pitch deck. List all target Chennai schools for ambassador recruitment. Finalise Google Form registration draft. Create core marketing material templates: event poster, Instagram post template, school invite letter.
Week 4Jul 22-28	Begin formal collaborator outreach. Internal website review and testing. Ambassador recruitment begins via Arnav and Maanas personal school contacts. Create final participant rules and guidelines document.

Phase 2: Collaborator Lock-In and Pre-Launch (Weeks 5-8 | Jul 29 - Aug 25, 2026)

Week	Goals and Key Activities
Week 5Jul 29 - Aug 4	Follow up on all collaborator outreach. Finalise judge count and profile requirements in collaboration with partner. Continue ambassador recruitment. Finalise all event documentation: rules, judging guide, participant FAQ, volunteer briefing template.
Week 6Aug 5-11	Collaborator agreement finalised and signed. Update all co-branding across website, posters, certificates, and social templates. Website soft launch: live but not broadly promoted. Ambassador orientation call conducted.
Week 7Aug 12-18	Official marketing blast: Silicon Circle social media pages go live on Instagram and LinkedIn. School invitation letters sent to all target Chennai school principals and activity coordinators. Press and community outreach begins. Domain and hosting confirmed and live.
Week 8Aug 19-25	Second wave of school outreach. Begin building pre-launch Discord community. Finalise venue shortlist for the finale and begin booking discussions. Confirm expected judge count with collaborator based on registration projections.

Phase 3: Pre-Registration (Weeks 9-10 | Aug 26 - Sep 20, 2026)

Week	Goals and Key Activities
Week 9Aug 26 - Sep 1	Full marketing push: countdown posts, theme reveal content, ambassador spotlight posts. Ambassadors begin generating interest and building registration waitlists at their schools. Prepare complete participant onboarding kit: welcome email, Discord guide, Team ID system, day-one checklist.
Week 10Sep 2-20	Schools enter exam period. Reduce public social media post frequency. Let ambassadors carry word-of-mouth communication. Finalise venue booking process and calculate per-head finale registration fee. Prepare Round 1 judge briefing materials. Draft GMeet Info Session slide deck.

Phase 4: Registration (September 22-25, 2026)

Date	Activity
Tue, Sep 10	REGISTRATIONS OPEN. Ambassador activation at all schools. Full social media marketing burst. WhatsApp broadcast to all waitlisted contacts and community members.

Thu, Sep 25	Mandatory GMeet Info Session. Welcome from Arnav and Maanas. Full event walkthrough, theme and category explanation, Discord onboarding, Q&A with all registered participants.
Wed-Thu, Sep 24-25	Final registration push. Ambassadors follow up with uncommitted teams. Monitor Discord and email queries and respond within 24 hours.
Thu, Sep 25 EOD	REGISTRATIONS CLOSE. Total team count confirmed. Path A (under 1,000) or Path B (1,000 and over) activated. Post-registration agenda, Team ID, and Round 1 schedule emailed to all teams.

Phase 5:

Date	Activity
Sep 26-28	Round 1: GMeet pitch slots assigned and conducted. Teams present their chosen theme, category, and solution idea live to judges.
Sep 29	Round 1 Results announced. Finalists confirmed. Individual written feedback sent to every team within 48 hours. Build Period begins. Private finalist Discord channel opens. Daily log requirement activates. Finale registration fee and payment link sent to finalists.
Sep 29 - Oct 12	Build Period active. Daily Discord progress uploads mandatory. Silicon Circle curates highlights for People's Choice social media posts. Teams continue developing their solutions.
Oct 12	Mid-build check-in message from Silicon Circle to all finalists. Reminder of stall format expectations and required materials for finale.
Oct 12-17	People's Choice Vote runs publicly on Instagram and LinkedIn. Certificates and trophies finalised. Venue confirmed and setup plan finalised. Final judge briefing document sent by Silicon Circle.
Fri, Oct 17	Finale Setup Day. Venue prepared. Volunteer briefing and role assignments. Stall numbers distributed to finalist teams.
Sat, Oct 18	FINALE DEMO DAY. Full schedule in Section 9.

Volunteers

Venue volunteers for the finale day will be recruited from the Silicon Circle community ambassadors approximately four weeks before the event. Volunteer roles include: entry and ID distribution, stall management support, timekeeping for judge rotations, lunch logistics, and general coordination. All volunteers receive a Silicon Circle Volunteer certificate.

Participant Support and Contact

A dedicated support email address and a Discord support channel will be maintained throughout the event. All participant queries will receive a response within 24 hours on weekdays. Silicon Circle is responsible for all communication with participants. The collaborator is not expected to handle any participant queries directly.